

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Engineering English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For mechanical, electrical, civil, systems, industrial, test, quality, manufacturing, and field engineers, plus engineering managers and technical project leads.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

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Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Turning a need into a requirement

02 Design review tradeoff

03 An unexpected test failure

04 Failure analysis review

05 Tolerance stack review

06 A supplier substitution

07 A field service escalation

08 Release readiness

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Turning a need into a requirement

A design team clarifies a customer's operating requirement.

Roles: Systems engineer / Mechanical engineer

Systems engineer: The customer says the enclosure must be easy to carry. How do we verify that?

Mechanical engineer: We need limits for mass, dimensions, and the intended carrying method.

Systems engineer: The draft specifies ten kilograms, but I can't find the source.

Mechanical engineer: Let's confirm that with the customer instead of treating it as approved.

Systems engineer: I'll record it as a proposed requirement with an open question.

Mechanical engineer: Include operating temperature and expected handling conditions in the review.

Systems engineer: Then we can link each approved requirement to a verification method.

Mechanical engineer: Right. That gives the design review a traceable basis for acceptance.

Notice the professional language

design review - A structured evaluation of a design at a defined stage.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Design review tradeoff

Engineers compare two housing materials.

Roles: Design engineer / Manufacturing engineer

Design engineer: Aluminum reduces mass, but machining time rises. Is the weight benefit worth the cost?

Manufacturing engineer: We need the same production volume and finish assumptions for both options.

Design engineer: My estimate used 500 units; yours used 5,000.

Manufacturing engineer: Then the unit costs aren't comparable yet.

Design engineer: I'll rerun the estimate at both volumes and include tooling cost.

Manufacturing engineer: I'll add tolerance capability and likely scrap during startup.

Design engineer: We'll present the tradeoff without declaring a winner from inconsistent figures.

Manufacturing engineer: And ask the product owner which requirement has priority if the targets conflict.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Aluminum reduces mass, but machining time rises. Is the weight benefit worth the cost?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

An unexpected test failure

A prototype fails a thermal test.

Roles: Test engineer / Design engineer

Test engineer: Unit three exceeded the temperature limit during the endurance run.

Design engineer: Was its configuration identical to units one and two?

Test engineer: Same drawing revision, but a different fan lot. The test log records both.

Design engineer: Keep the failed unit intact. We need to distinguish a design issue from a component variation.

Test engineer: I'll preserve the raw data and check the sensor calibration status.

Design engineer: I'll compare the build records before proposing another test.

Test engineer: Should I mark verification complete for the other units?

Design engineer: Record their results, but leave the overall requirement status pending review.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Was its configuration identical to units one and two?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Failure analysis review

A field failure has prompted competing explanations.

Roles: Reliability engineer / Materials engineer

Reliability engineer: The fracture surface suggests fatigue, but we haven't established the initiation site.

Materials engineer: There may be corrosion near the edge. Do we have the service history?

Reliability engineer: Only operating hours. The customer is collecting load and environmental records.

Materials engineer: Then let's keep both hypotheses open.

Reliability engineer: I'll add the missing evidence to the investigation plan.

Materials engineer: Preserve the fracture surfaces before any cleaning or destructive examination.

Reliability engineer: We'll distinguish observations from interpretations in the interim report.

Materials engineer: Good. The corrective action should follow the evidence, not our first impression.

Notice the professional language

corrective action - Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Tolerance stack review

A team investigates an assembly fit problem.

Roles: Mechanical engineer / Quality engineer

Mechanical engineer: Every component passes inspection, but some assemblies bind.

Quality engineer: Have we checked the tolerance stack at the mating features?

Mechanical engineer: Yes. The worst-case combination leaves no clearance.

Quality engineer: Then tightening one supplier's dimension may not solve the whole stack.

Mechanical engineer: I'll review datum selection and the functional requirement with design.

Quality engineer: We should also check measurement methods between suppliers.

Mechanical engineer: I'll prepare the stack analysis and proposed drawing changes.

Quality engineer: Keep the current nonconforming assemblies identified until disposition is approved.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Have we checked the tolerance stack at the mating features?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A supplier substitution

A supplier proposes an alternative component.

Roles: Supplier engineer / Design engineer

Supplier engineer: Our usual bearing is unavailable. The substitute has the same outside dimensions.

Design engineer: Dimensions alone aren't enough. What about load rating, speed, seals, and lubrication?

Supplier engineer: I can provide the manufacturer's data and a cross-reference.

Design engineer: Please include any differences and the affected purchase orders.

Supplier engineer: Can production fit it while you review?

Design engineer: Substitution needs approval first. We'll assess whether additional verification is required.

Supplier engineer: I'll hold the change and send the complete technical package.

Design engineer: I'll identify the review owner and give planning an update on the assessment.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Dimensions alone aren't enough. What about load rating, speed, seals, and lubrication?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A field service escalation

Service reports an intermittent fault to engineering.

Roles: Field service engineer / Product engineer

Field service engineer: The actuator stalls after warming up, then works again after cooling.

Product engineer: What firmware and hardware revisions are installed?

Field service engineer: Revision C hardware, firmware 2.4. I have the event log and serial number.

Product engineer: Has anyone changed settings since the fault appeared?

Field service engineer: No. I documented the observed behavior and left the unit in its approved safe state.

Product engineer: I'll compare the logs with the known-issue register.

Field service engineer: The customer needs a next step, even if we don't have a root cause.

Product engineer: Tell them engineering is reviewing the evidence; I'll provide the next diagnostic plan through service.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What firmware and hardware revisions are installed?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Release readiness

Engineering prepares to release a drawing package.

Roles: Design lead / Configuration manager

Design lead: Can we release revision D today?

Configuration manager: The drawings are signed, but the bill of materials still references revision C of the bracket.

Design lead: That needs correcting. Are any other linked documents inconsistent?

Configuration manager: The inspection plan also uses the old datum scheme.

Design lead: I'll update those references and request the required reviews.

Configuration manager: I'll run the configuration check again after approval.

Design lead: Please keep the release status pending until the package is consistent.

Configuration manager: Agreed. I'll notify manufacturing when the controlled revision is actually available.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can we release revision D today?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Requirements and Constraints

SHARED CASE

A customer asks for a "lightweight and durable" enclosure without specifying weight, operating conditions, or required life.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you define the target weight, operating conditions, and expected life? We need measurable requirements to discuss the tradeoffs and evaluate a design consistently.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Design Reviews and Technical Pushback

SHARED CASE

A design review is moving toward approval while one interface assumption remains undocumented.

Role A | Responding professional

State a concern respectfully and propose a practical route forward. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want to move quickly and initially overlook a relevant condition. Ask why it matters, then consider a practical route forward that respects the real constraint.

Useful expressions

I understand the goal. My concern is

That statement goes beyond

Could we ... before confirming ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I support moving the review forward, but this interface assumption needs to be explicit. Could we record it and identify the verification needed before treating that part of the design as settled?

Second round

The other person repeats the request more firmly. Restate the specific concern calmly and explain the appropriate next route.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Failure Modes and Reliability

SHARED CASE

A component fails during one test. The team has not reproduced the failure or checked the test setup.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The failure occurred in this test, but its mechanism is not established. I'll describe the observed behavior and test conditions separately from the possible explanations.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Testing, Validation, and Data Interpretation

SHARED CASE

A prototype passes a test on three samples. A presentation calls the design proven for every operating condition.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The three samples met the criteria under the tested conditions. That does not establish performance under every condition. I'll state the sample size and limits of the test clearly.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Manufacturability and Cost Engineering

SHARED CASE

Two designs use different tooling and assembly steps. One has a lower material cost but higher assembly time.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The material cost favors the first design, while assembly time favors the second. Let's compare the full manufacturing assumptions before calling either design cheaper overall.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Safety Factors and Compliance

SHARED CASE

A review note says a design is "compliant" without identifying the applicable requirement or review evidence.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you identify the requirement, revision, and supporting evidence for that statement? We need a traceable basis for the compliance claim and review by the responsible specialist.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Field Issues and Customer Communication

SHARED CASE

A customer received a field-failure update that stated an unconfirmed cause as fact. The investigation is still open.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

Our earlier update overstated the cause. The investigation is still open, and the confirmed finding is the observed failure described below. I'm sorry for the confusion; we'll clearly label hypotheses in future updates.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Systems Integration and Interface Control

SHARED CASE

A hardware interface changed after software testing began. The integration team needs the version and affected tests.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Cover this until after your first attempt

The interface changed in this revision. I've listed the affected signals and tests for review. Please confirm the configuration your team will use and which checks need to be repeated.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.